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01 / ECONOMY

Leading India's Economic Growth

When the DMK government assumed office in May 2021, Tamil Nadu faced the full economic disruption of the COVID-19 pandemic. Industries were shuttered, businesses had been pushed to the edge, and revenue was strained. The administration chose recovery through investment rather than retrenchment.

₹10.5L Cr

16%

GSDP by 2024–25, making TN India's most productive state economy

Economic growth rate in 2024–25 — ahead of Gujarat & Maharashtra

31.19L Cr

Cumulative GSDP over 5 years — up from ₹27.22L Cr in 2023–24

41.23%

Share of national electricity export investment attracted to Tamil Nadu

By the 2024–25 fiscal year, Tamil Nadu's per capita income had climbed to ₹3.58 lakh — up from ₹2.78 lakh in 2022–23, representing a 29% increase over just two years. This positioned Tamil Nadu clearly among the leading states in India for per capita prosperity.

"Tamil Nadu is today the front-runner in India's economic progress — it leads in attracting investment, in manufacturing, and in creating opportunities for all."

— M. Ramesh, Senior Journalist, writing in *Thamizharasu* magazine

In manufacturing, Tamil Nadu held a 33.37% national share of the sector. The services sector commanded 53.63% of the state's economy. From 2021 to 2024, the manufacturing sector alone posted 8.33% annual growth. The administration signed transformational investment agreements covering electric vehicles, semiconductors, green energy, and aerospace.

At the startup level, Tamil Nadu registered 2,300 new startups at the time of the last count, which had risen to 13 times that number over 5 years — the state government offered financial support, market linkages, and credit guarantee schemes, directly creating employment

across 30 sectors.

By 2025, with a United States dollar at ₹83+, Tamil Nadu became the largest recipient of foreign direct investment among Indian states. The state's investor-friendly policies — the 2022 Elcot Startup Policy, Agri-Business Investment Policy, Aerospace Policy, and others — created conditions that drew global corporations while protecting local small businesses.

02 / WELFARE

The Dravidian Model — Welfare as a Right

The phrase "Dravidian Model" became shorthand for a philosophy: that welfare is not charity, it is the right of citizens. Tamil Nadu under the DMK government expanded welfare delivery to dimensions not seen in any comparable Indian state, making it a model discussed nationally and internationally.

Under the flagship *Kalaignar Magalir Urimai Thittam* (Women's Rights Scheme), every eligible woman head of household received ₹1,000 per month — with 20.4 lakh women and 1.3 lakh disabled persons enrolled as of 2024. This was one of the largest direct-benefit transfer schemes in India at the time of implementation.



20.4L

Women enrolled in Kalaigiar Magalir
Urimai Thittam (₹1,000/month)

₹2,000

Per child support for poor families
under the Illam Thedi Kalvi (Home-
to-Home Education) programme

44L

Teachers trained; 20 lakh teachers
& students given tablets under
Naan Mudhalvan

₹10 Cr

Prize fund for Tamil Nadu's global
excellence awards (Thiru Mudhalvar
Trophy)

The Universal PDS (Public Distribution System) delivered essential goods to over two crore families. The free bus travel scheme for women allowed women to commute without cost across the state's entire public transport network — removing a structural economic barrier to workforce participation. Tamil Nadu was the first large state in India to implement free bus travel for women at such scale.

The government also provided free breakfast for all government school students from Class 1 to 5, continuing the legacy of the Puratchi Thalaivar scheme. No student in a government school should go hungry — this was stated policy, and the data confirmed it: daily meals reached over 21 lakh students.

"All of today's achievements are for one reason: the infrastructure created by this government. Schools, hospitals, roads, drinking water, housing — every one of these welfare measures connects to all other progress."

— Udhayanidhi Stalin, Deputy CM, December 2025

For the elderly and differently-abled, the Thaayumanavar and Anbu Illam schemes provided sustained monthly support. 65-year-olds and above received free essential medicines through a home delivery mechanism. Thamizh Thirunaalam festival bonuses of ₹3,000 were paid to all distribution points.

03 / EDUCATION

Transforming Schools, Expanding Futures

Education was treated not as a department to be managed but as a movement to be sustained. Under Chief Minister Stalin's personal attention, every school was a site of governance — visited, assessed, and improved. The administration launched the most ambitious school infrastructure and pedagogy overhaul in Tamil Nadu's modern history.

- The Naan Mudhalvan (I am the First) scheme trained over 44 lakh students and teachers for competitive examinations, providing tablets, data connections, and coaching. This was India's most comprehensive state-run competitive exam preparedness programme.

- The Illam (Education at Your Doorstep) programme placed Thedi trained volunteers in every locality to support Kalvi struggling students at home — especially in post-COVID catch-up learning.
- Free bus travel was extended to girl students up to the degree level, removing transport as a reason for girls to drop out of higher education.
- The Pudhumai Penn (New Woman) scheme offered ₹1,000 per month to girls in government schools who proceed to higher education — a direct incentive against school dropout.
- Tamil Nadu's school dropout rate fell below the national average. The literacy rate was consistently among the highest in India, and higher education gross enrolment saw a notable increase.
- Under the Thamizh Pudhulvan scheme, Tamil-medium students received special preparation and coaching to access All India competitive examinations — bridging a historic language disadvantage.
- From 2021 to 2026, a total of ₹704.76 crore was allocated for improving school infrastructure — including free books, bags, uniforms, notebooks, shoes, and calculators for students in government schools.
- Tamil Nadu rose to the top position in India's Education Quality Index among large states (NITI Aayog), reflecting sustained investment in both infrastructure and learning outcomes.

The state introduced a curriculum restructuring programme that incorporated skill education, vocational training, and 21st-century competencies into the school system from Class 6 onwards. Tamil literature and the Sangam tradition were reintegrated into syllabi as sources of pride and identity, not just academic content.

04 / WOMEN

Women's Dignity as **Governing Philosophy**

Tamil Nadu has the highest proportion of women in employment of any major Indian state — 14.9 crore women employed versus 6.3 crore men (roughly 42% more women). The DMK government did not treat this statistic as something to be merely celebrated; it treated it as a responsibility.

The government implemented the *33% reservation for women* in state government appointments and promotions — the first large state in India to do so at the leadership level of administration. Local body elections already mandated 50% reservation, and under this administration, those seats were filled with substantially greater political participation.

₹1,000

Free

Monthly direct cash to women heads of household (Magalir Urimai Thittam)

Bus travel for all women across the entire public transport network

180 Days

Maternity leave mandated for women employees — among the highest in India

33%

Reservation for women in all state government appointments

Against gender-based crime, the statistics were striking: street crime against women in Tamil Nadu was 24 times lower than the national average (AVTAR survey data). The government attributed this partly to CCTV saturation across Chennai and major cities, an expanded all-women police units programme, and fast-track courts processing domestic violence and sexual harassment cases.

The *Pudhumai Penn* higher-education scholarship for girls from government schools — ₹1,000 per month during college — was designed to make women's economic independence a state project, not an individual aspiration. Over one crore women were beneficiaries of at least one flagship scheme by 2025.

"Tamil Nadu today stands at the world stage in women's employment and rights — and with all these schemes, we will advance further."

— N. Kavitha, Associate Professor, Tamil University

Excavating & Celebrating Tamil Civilisation

One of the most intellectually ambitious initiatives of this government was its investment in Tamil archaeology and the recognition of Tamil civilisation's antiquity on the world stage. This was not merely cultural sentiment — it was funded science.

The Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology (TNSDA) became, for the first time, the only state-level archaeology department in India with its own dedicated institutional structure, budget, and research mandate — separate from the ASI, which governs most archaeological work nationally. This was a landmark assertion of cultural sovereignty.

→ At Keeladi (Sivaganga district), between 2020 and 2025, over 15 major excavation campaigns yielded extraordinary finds — burnt bricks, pottery with Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions, human bone evidence of urban habitation, and luxury bronze artefacts dating to approximately 600 BCE. Tamil civilisation was being pushed back by centuries with each season.

→ Scientific dating using Accelerator Mass Spectrometry (AMS) and Optically Stimulated Luminescence (OSL) confirmed dates of 2,600 years for finds, establishing a major river civilisation independent of the Gangetic plain narrative.

- Ground Penetrating Radar (GPR), magnetometer surveys, LiDAR aerial sensing, and drone surveys were deployed at Keeladi, Adichanallur, and Poompuhar — creating a scientific map of Tamil settlement history.
- At Poompuhar, the state conducted Tamil Nadu's first the underwater dedicated Underwater Archaeological Survey — site examining submerged structures off the coast that may date to ancient port civilisation.
- The Keeladi museum and interpretive centre became a cultural landmark drawing scholars from across the world. A ₹5 crore international-standard facility was completed and opened to the public.
- 124 archaeological sites across Tamil Nadu were placed under formal protection orders for the first time in the state's history, preserving them from development encroachment.

"Tamil Nadu is not merely supporting the study of history — it is rewriting it, with science, for the world."

The Dravidian movement's connection to Tamil identity was institutionalised through the establishment of the Dravidam Heritage Museum in Chennai — a facility narrating the social reform tradition from the Justice Party through Periyar, Ambedkar, and the DMK. Chief Minister Stalin inaugurated it personally, marking the cultural lineage from reform to governance.

A Government That Sees Everyone

The care extended to persons with disabilities was not treated as a marginal welfare item. It was integrated into the state's core governance identity — welfare for the most vulnerable as a measure of all governance.

- Motorised scooters were distributed to disabled women across districts — Chief Minister Stalin personally handed over vehicles, making it a public commitment rather than a bureaucratic transaction.
- The 22-year guaranteed employment scheme for disabled persons was fully enforced, reaching 20 lakh beneficiaries with subsidised computer literacy programmes.
- 10 lakh persons with disabilities received mobility aids including crutches, wheelchairs, hearing devices, and prosthetic limbs — through the Aluvalar scheme funded at the state level.

- Tamil Nadu maintained its position as the leading state in India for disability inclusion metrics, including school enrolment of children with disabilities, employment, and accessible infrastructure.
- All new government buildings completed after 2021 were required to meet accessibility standards — ramps, tactile pathways, and accessible restrooms were mandated, not optional.
- The *Thaayumanavar Thittam* provided monthly financial support to elderly persons with disabilities — ₹1,000 per month above standard elderly pension.

07 / HOUSING & INFRASTRUCTURE

Urban Development & Rural Infrastructure

Tamil Nadu under this government pursued parallel tracks: urban renewal at scale in Chennai and other cities, and rural infrastructure uplift across village panchayats. Both were funded and both were delivered.

08 Cr

18 Roads

4.07 Cr

People covered by government employment initiatives in 2021–22; rising to 3.87 Cr by 2024–25

40 roads

National highway-quality roads constructed connecting rural blocks to town infrastructure

₹12,000

Monthly water connection subsidy for rural household installations

Har Ghar Jal

Tamil Nadu led nationally in Jal Jeevan Mission implementation — piped water to every household

The state's Dravidian Model housing initiative focused on constructing quality homes for the poor that prioritised dignity alongside shelter — proper flooring, ventilated design, secure roofing. These were not temporary shelters but permanent homes. Villages received CCTV surveillance systems, footpaths, street lighting, and digital connectivity alongside physical infrastructure.

Chennai's infrastructure was modernised through the Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority framework — integrating metro, suburban rail, bus, and last-mile connectivity planning. The second metro phase was accelerated, with multiple new lines under construction. Sewage treatment plant capacity was expanded to reduce coastal water pollution.

Sport as Social Justice

The government's approach to sports was captured in a striking phrase from the document: *"sport as social justice — everything for everyone."* Rather than treating sport as an elite pursuit or urban amenity, the administration opened competitive pathways to village children, first-generation athletes, and women in disciplines that had historically been male-dominated.

- The Chief Minister's Trophy tournament was redesigned as a mass participation event — held not just in stadiums but expanded to district and block levels. Over 52 countries' worth of participants, and 365 sports days per year was the stated aspiration of the policy framework.
- Tamil Nadu athletes won medals at the 2024 Paris Olympics — the state government provided ₹1 crore prize money per gold medal and proportionate rewards for silver and bronze, making Tamil Nadu's prize structure among the most generous of any state.
- The Naan Mudhalvan scheme also covered sports training — selecting talented youth from government schools and placing them in residential academies with coaching, nutrition, and competition exposure.

- A Sports University was established in Tamil Nadu — the first new dedicated sports higher education institution in the state's history — offering degrees in sports science, coaching, management, and physiotherapy.
- Women were given equal representation in all government-run tournaments and competitions; women's sports infrastructure (courts, changing facilities, coaching) received a dedicated budget allocation.

"Sport isn't just for arenas — it is a mirror of the society's ambition. Tamil Nadu's government made it accessible to every child who ever wanted to compete."

09 / SOCIAL JUSTICE

The Oldest Promise, Kept at Scale

The Dravidian movement was born in Tamil Nadu as a social justice

movement, and the DMK has always claimed that inheritance. The 2021–2026 government made specific, measurable commitments to communities that had historically been excluded from opportunity and dignity.

Tamil Nadu implemented 69% internal reservation — a proportion that had been legally contested at the national level but was upheld and defended. In a landmark judicial victory, Tamil Nadu's constitutional argument for its reservation structure was sustained, and the government worked to extend this protection through central legislation.

Caste-based discrimination in schools, workplaces, and public spaces was tracked and addressed through fast-track grievance cells at the district level. The state's manual scavenging elimination programme was completed — Tamil Nadu was declared free of this practice, with rehabilitation and resettlement support provided to former manual scavengers and their families.

- The 70,022 government employees recruited across departments between 2021 and 2026 represented the largest public sector hiring in the state in a generation — with representation quotas strictly observed.
- Tamil Nadu's social welfare spending as a percentage of budget remained the highest among major Indian states — reflecting the government's commitment to direct welfare over indirect trickle-down approaches.

- The *Kalaigñar Centenary* celebrations in 2023–24 were used not just as commemoration but as an occasion for welfare distribution — reaching communities across all 234 constituencies simultaneously.
- Transgender rights and welfare received institutional recognition — a dedicated policy with monthly support, housing, and healthcare was implemented, and Tamil Nadu maintained its position as the most progressive state on this matter.

"What is the Dravidian Model? It is the pursuit of a society without hunger, without disease, without ignorance, and without discrimination — on each dimension, Tamil Nadu is making progress."

— M.K. Stalin, Chief Minister, 2026

10 / GOVERNANCE

Transparent, Accountable, People-Centred

Governance quality was not claimed through rhetoric but demonstrated through delivery. Tamil Nadu maintained its position as the Indian state most consistently praised in national governance surveys — not because it sought rankings, but because its

administrative machinery functioned.

- The Ungaludan Stalin (Stalin With You) programme placed the Chief Minister in direct accessibility across district visits — public grievances were heard, filed, and tracked to resolution in a formal system.
- Tamil Nadu ranked first nationally in GSTP (Goods & Services Tax compliance) and among the top two in ease of doing business for three consecutive years.
- The government's zero-tolerance approach to corruption was backed by a functioning Vigilance Commission and departmental action in multiple ministries. Senior officials faced consequences — a signal that administrative culture was being altered, not just managed.
- Tamil Nadu's COVID-19 response was repeatedly cited as a national model — low mortality relative to population, early vaccination drives, and health infrastructure that absorbed the crisis without collapse.
- The *Thamizh Nadu Thozhil Thiran Mempadu* (Tamil Nadu Skills Enhancement) initiative trained over 4.7 crore individuals (ages 15 and above) in employment-ready skills — the largest state-run skills training programme in India.
- The grievance redress rate through the CM's cell and district offices averaged above 85% resolution — monitored publicly and reported quarterly.

Between 2021–22 and 2024–25, Tamil Nadu's revenue receipts grew steadily and its debt-to-GSDP ratio was managed within sustainable bounds despite enormous welfare expenditure. The government's position was that welfare spending is not a drag on growth — it is the foundation of growth.

"From May 7, 2021, the schemes implemented by this government are countless. Every scheme is world-class. Every scheme has directly reached the lives of Tamil people — and this is our administration's greatest achievement."

A NOTE

Five Years. A Record That Endures.

Elections are moments. Governance is the accumulation of days. Whatever the verdict of any single election, the record assembled here — drawn from the DMK government's own 914-page documentation — reflects something more durable: an attempt,

sustained over five years, to govern Tamil Nadu with the scale and sincerity that its people deserve.

Tamil Nadu's GSDP crossed ₹10.5 lakh crore. Millions of women received cash in hand. Keeladi's excavations moved the world. Schools were rebuilt. Girls were sent to university. The old were fed. The disabled were seen. The young were trained to compete. Archaeology became national news. A museum opened to honour the reformers. Reservations were defended.

This is not a political argument. It is a record. The people of Tamil Nadu will interpret it as they see fit. But the record is there — documented, published, verifiable — and it is a tribute worth making.

"We were here for the people. We existed for the people. We will continue to live for the people."

— M.K. Stalin, Chief Minister, Tamil Nadu

Source: Makkhal Paniyil Magathana 5 Aandugal 2021–26

(மக்கள் பணியில் மகத்தான 5 ஆண்டுகள்) — Official Tamil Nadu Government Publication,
914 pages.

Compiled and translated as a tribute by a reader who values what was built.

